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Are Skittles dangerous? - A proposed California bill aims to - ban several chemicals in candy

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Lawmakers in California want to ban chemicals in popular rainbow candies and processed foods - including Skittles, Nerds, Hot Tamales, cake icing and Strawberry Nesquik.

A proposed bill is seeking to halt the manufacture, sale or distribution of any food product in the state containing red dye No. 3, titanium dioxide, potassium bromate, brominated vegetable oil or propylparaben, arguing that those chemicals are "dangerous" and already banned in the European Union and other countries.

Despite headlines about a possible "ban" on Skittles in California, that isn't about to happen - it's unclear whether the bill has enough momentum to pass, and it would still have a long way to go before it could become legislation.

Even the lawmaker behind the bill says, "there's a 0% chance this is actually going to result in a ban of Skittles." Instead, Jesse Gabriel (D-Woodland Hills) hopes that companies will adjust their recipes as they have done for other countries.

Several food industry groups sent a letter last week against the proposed bill saying that "All five of these additives have been thoroughly reviewed by the federal and state systems and many international scientific bodies and continue to be deemed safe."

The National Confectioners Association said in a statement Thursday that "food safety is the number one priority for U.S. confectionery companies, and we do not use any ingredients in our products that do not comply with the FDA's strictest safety standards."

Here's what you need to know about each of the chemicals, and whether they are dangerous.

What is titanium dioxide, used in Skittles, Nerds and other candies?

Titanium dioxide is a white food colorant often used in candies and processed foods to give a smooth texture. "The pigment can brighten other colors, making the food more vibrant and appealing, but the additive has no nutritional benefit," says the Environmental Working Group, a consumer advocacy organization that is pushing for the legislation.

Titanium dioxide is found in the U.S. recipe for Skittles, but does not feature in bags of the sweets sold or consumed in Europe, since it was banned by the European Union last year. It is also found in Nerds candy.

The European Union banned it after saying an evaluation found it could "no longer be considered safe when used as a food additive." The European Food Safety Authority (EFSA) said it could not exclude the possibility the additive could lead to carcinogenic effects. The agency noted that its assessment showed that "after oral ingestion, the absorption of titanium dioxide particles is low, however they can accumulate in the body."

In 2017, a European review published in the peer-reviewed journal Nature said that titanium dioxide could accumulate in the body, including a person's bloodstream, kidney, liver and spleen.

The Food and Drug Administration says it can be safely used for coloring foods, as long as it does not exceed 1% of the weight by food.

Some researchers have argued that current safety regulations to approve titanium dioxide were based on reviews held decades ago and should be reassessed by governments.

Callie Noakes, a spokesperson for Skittles's parent company Mars, said in an email: "We always follow local regulatory rules, and all of our treats and snacks are made to the very highest quality and adhere to the strictest safety standards."

When asked about the difference in the U.S. and European versions of Skittles, Noakes acknowledged that the "recipes vary slightly across the globe," adding that "this is largely to accommodate manufacturing capabilities, local availability of raw material, or the different taste preferences of people."

Is red dye No. 3 dangerous?

Red dye No. 3, also known as Erythrosine or E 127, is used in products, including Hot Tamales and Peeps marshmallows.

The production company of both, Just Born, credits the additive with providing "a distinct and recognizable color," adding that certified food colors are "highly regulated for purity and each batch produced must meet exacting standards and be approved by the FDA before they can be sold by the manufacturer."

In the European Union, it is only authorized for use in certain cocktail cherries or candied cherries.

In 1990, the FDA banned the use of red dye No. 3 in cosmetics and externally applied drugs, based on its analysis of unpublished animal research suggesting a link to thyroid cancer. The agency, though, still allows its use in thousands of foods, dietary supplements and ingested drugs.

There is no evidence that ingesting red dye No. 3 or any other artificial food colors causes cancer in humans. Scientists, however, tend to use results of animal studies to understand possible effects in people.

The International Association of Color Manufacturers, which represents the dye industry, defended dye safety, specifically red dye No. 3, pointing to its long and widespread use.

Other studies have connected several artificial dyes, including red dye No. 3, to hyperactivity and other behavioral problems in children.

What is potassium bromate?

Potassium bromate, often found in baked goods, has been banned in food in countries including India, Brazil, Canada and across Europe. Britain banned the flour improver in 1990 over fears the substance was a carcinogen - an item capable of causing cancer.

The European Union's chemicals agency, meanwhile, describes the substance as "toxic if swallowed" and says it "may cause cancer."

The FDA says it can "safely be used in the malting of barley" under certain prescribed conditions.

According to the Environmental Working Group, potassium bromate was approved for use in the United States by the FDA in the 1960s, but the chemical has not been assessed since the 1970s.

In California, products containing the oxidizing agent need to carry a cancer warning.

What is brominated vegetable oil, and where is it used?

Brominated vegetable oil (BVO) is a food additive that is sometimes used to stop ingredients from separating and

floating to the top of beverages.

It is banned as a food additive in Europe, but is still found in Sun Drop citrus soda in the United States. The FDA allows it to be used "in a small amount" but says it has "identified areas where additional information about possible health effects is needed."

Bromine has been found to aggravate skin membranes, and drinking extremely large quantities has been linked to neurological symptoms such as memory loss and headaches, according to the Mayo Clinic.

In 2014, Coca-Cola announced it would be removing the ingredient from Powerade and the rest of its products after a Mississippi teenager's online petition against the additive gained more than 200,000 signatures. Pepsi also removed BVO from products, including Gatorade.

What is propylparaben?

Propylparaben is a preservative that is used in cosmetics, and used as a food additive. It is found in various baked goods, including certain cake icing brands.

The FDA says propylparaben is "generally recognized as safe" as long as it does not exceed 0.1% in food. It is not approved for use as a preservative in foods in the European Union, though, following research that suggested propylparaben had an impact on the reproductive system in male rats.

The Environmental Working Group says the preservative is "linked to disruptions in hormone signaling." Some critics have argued, however, that the research on rats from the early-2000s is outdated and that European food safety regulators should review its use in food again.

During a 2005-2006 study, scientists from the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention found propylparaben in the urine of most of the people they tested, indicating widespread exposure to these parabens in the U.S. population. They added, however, that "finding a measurable amount of parabens in urine does not imply that they cause an adverse health effect."

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